The October Game

By Ray Bradbury

MICH: **(Pg 787-792)** *(Holding up a gun and examining it closely – he shakes his head an places the gun back in a bureau drawer)* No, not that way. Louise wouldn't suffer that way. She would be dead and it would be over and she wouldn't suffer. It's very important that this thing have, above all, duration. Duration through imagination. How to prolong the suffering? How, first of all, to bring it about? Well . . .

INTRODUCTION

The October Game by Ray Bradbury

NARRATOR: He paused long enough to hear the children run by swiftly on the street below, outside this warm two-story house; like so many gray mice the children, like so many leaves. By the sound of the children, you knew the calendar day. By their screams you knew what evening it was. The last day of October, with white bone masks and cut pumpkins and the smell of

4NG Fanatics

dropped candle fat. There was a soft running in the hall.

MICH: That's Marion. My little one. All eight quiet years of her.

NARRATOR: His daughter had been in and out all evening, trying on various masks, asking him which was most terrifying, most horrible. They had both finally decided on the skeleton mask. It was "just awful!" It would "scare the beans" from people!

He had never liked October. Ever since he first lay in the autumn leaves before his grandmother's house many years ago and hear the wind and saw the empty trees. It had made him cry, without a reason. And a little of that sadness returned each year to him. It always went away with spring.

But, it was different tonight. There would be no spring. He had been crying quietly all evening. It did not show on his face. It was all hidden somewhere and it wouldn't stop.

There was a mouse-rustle in the hall. Marion appeared in the door, all skeletonous in her disguise.

MARION: How do I Look, Papa?

NARRATOR: From under the mask, blonde hair showed. From the skull sockets small blue eyes smiled. What alchemy had there been in Louise that bleached the dark brown eyes and black hair of a dark man? She had produced a child in her ***own*** image, and, to top it, she had somehow ***fixed*** the doctor.

DOCTOR: *(shaking his head)* Sorry, Mr. Wilder, your wife will never have another child. This is the ***last*** one.

MICH: And I wanted a boy.

NARRATOR: He almost bent to take hold of Marion now, in her skull mask. He felt pity for her, because she had never had a father's love, only the crushing love of a loveless mother. But most of all he pitied himself, that he had not made the most of a bad birth, enjoyed his daughter for herself, regardless of her not being dark and a son and like himself. Somewhere he had missed out.

Now it was October again. There had been other Octobers and when he thought of the endless months trapped with a woman and child, neither of whom loved him, he had been filled with horror . . . year after year. He simply could not wear this one through. There

4NG Fanatics

was an acid walled off in him that slowly had eaten through tissue and bone over the years, and now, tonight, it would reach the wild explosive in him and all would be over!

MICH: *(hesitating)* What was all this? Where had it gone wrong? Certainly not with the birth of the child alone.

NARRATOR: Why didn't he just turn, pack a suitcase, and leave? No. Not without hurting Louise as much as she had hurt him. It was simple as that. Divorce wouldn't hurt her at all. It would simply be an end to numb indecision. If divorce would give her pleasure in any way, he would stay married the rest of his life . . . for damned spite. No, he must hurt her.

MICH: Figure some way, perhaps, to take Marion away from her, legally. Yes! That was it. That would hurt most of all. To take Marion away. *(He smiles as disturbing smile and bends to scoop Marion up in his arms)* Here we go . . . *(he exits with her to the cellar)*

*****

MICH: *(mimes, washing his hands and face and drying them off with a towel)*

NARRATOR: [Later that evening] there was a mad ringing of the bell below. There were vast bowls of punch, stringed apples in each door. There was a water tub in the center of the living room, waiting, with a sack of apples nearby, for dunking. There were shouts and hilarity. He walked to the top of the stairs. Louise was below, tall and slender and blonde, laughing down upon the new children.

MICH: *(putting on his party mask, he shouts with forced happiness)* Hello down there!

CHILD: *(shouting and waving)* Hi, Mr. Wilder!

NARRATOR: He took the party right out of Louise's hands. He supervised pin the tail on the donkey, spin the bottle, and musical chairs, amid fits of shouting laughter. Then, all house lights out, he cried . . .

MICH: Hush! Follow me! *(tiptoeing toward the cellar)*

NARRATOR: The parents commented to each other, nodding at the clever husband, speaking to the lucky wife. How well he got on with children they said.

MICH: *(In an ominous whisper)* The cellar! The tomb of the witch! *(mock shivering he speaks the incantation loudly)* Abandon hope all ye who enter here!

4NG Fanatics

NARRATOR: The parents chuckled. Everybody talked at once. Everybody but Marion. The upper house was empty and silent in the candle-shine . . . They sat in a vast circle in the cellar. Twenty squealing children, twelve relatives, with Louise down at the far end. The entire program from here on was to be enacted in the dark.

MICH: Now! Quiet! . . . . The witch is dead, she has been killed, and here is the knife she was killed with.

NARRATOR: He handed over the knife. It was passed from hand to hand around the circle . . .

MICH: *(whispering)* The witch is dead, and this is her head. *(handing another item to be passed around)*

CHILD: *(excitedly)* Oh, I know this game! He gets some old chicken innards from the ice box and hands them around and says, "These are her innards!" I know how this is played!

CHILD 2: Hush you'll spoil everything!

MICH: The witch came to harm, and this is her arm!

NARRATOR: The items were passed and passed around the circle. Some children screamed, wouldn't touch them.

CHILD: Eeeee!

CHILD 2: *(giggling)* Aw, it's only chicken insides. Come back, Helen!

MICH: The witch cut apart, and this is her heart.

LOUISE: Marion, don't be afraid; its only play. *(silence)* Marion? Are you afraid? *(silence)*

MICH: She's all right. She's not afraid.

NARRATOR: On and on the passing, the screams, the hilarity. The autumn wind signed about the house. And he, the husband, stood at the head of the dark cellar, intoning the words, handing out the items.

LOUISE: Marion? Marion? Marion, answer me, are you afraid? *(Silence)* Where's Marion?

CHILD: Maybe she's upstairs?

LOUISE: Marion, Marion! *(panicking)* Turn on the lights!

NARRATOR: Everybody quieted. The items stopped passing. The children and adults sat with the witch's items in their hands.

LOUISE: *(gasping)* No . . . No . . . Don't turn on the lights, oh, God! God, don't turn them on, please. *(voice rising to a shriek)* Don't turn on the lights, don't!

NARRATOR: Nobody moved. Everyone sat in the dark cellar, suspended in the suddenly frozen task of this

4NG Fanatics

October game. The wind blew outside, banging the house. The smell of pumpkins and apples filled the room with the smell of the objects in their fingers.

CHILD: I'll go upstairs and look!

NARRATOR: And he ran upstairs hopefully and out around the house, four time around, calling

CHILD: Marion . . . Marion . . . Marion!

NARRATOR: At last, coming slowly down the stairs into the waiting cellar and saying to the darkness

CHILD: I can't find her.

NARRATOR: Then . . . some idiot turned on the lights.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Ray Bradbury
Book: Stories of Ray Bradbury, Pg 787-792
ISBN: 978-0394513355
Publisher: Knopf
Date (Month/Year): 1980

AWARD HISTORY

KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier